

What is linguistics?

Linguistics is the scientific study of language, and its focus is the systematic investigation of the properties of particular languages as well as the characteristics of language in general. It examines the structure, meaning, and use of languages. It encompasses not only the study of sound, grammar, and meaning but also the history of language families, how languages are acquired by children and adults, how language is processed in the mind, and how it is connected to race and gender. With close connections to the humanities, social sciences, and natural sciences, linguistics complements a diverse range of other disciplines such as anthropology, philosophy, psychology, sociology, biology, computer science, health sciences, education, and literature. The subfield of applied linguistics emphasizes the use of linguistic concepts in the classroom to help students improve their ability to communicate in their native language or a second language.

What is the importance of linguistics?

Areas of Study: Linguistics investigates various aspects of language, including sound, grammar, and meaning. It also explores the history of language families and how languages evolve over time.

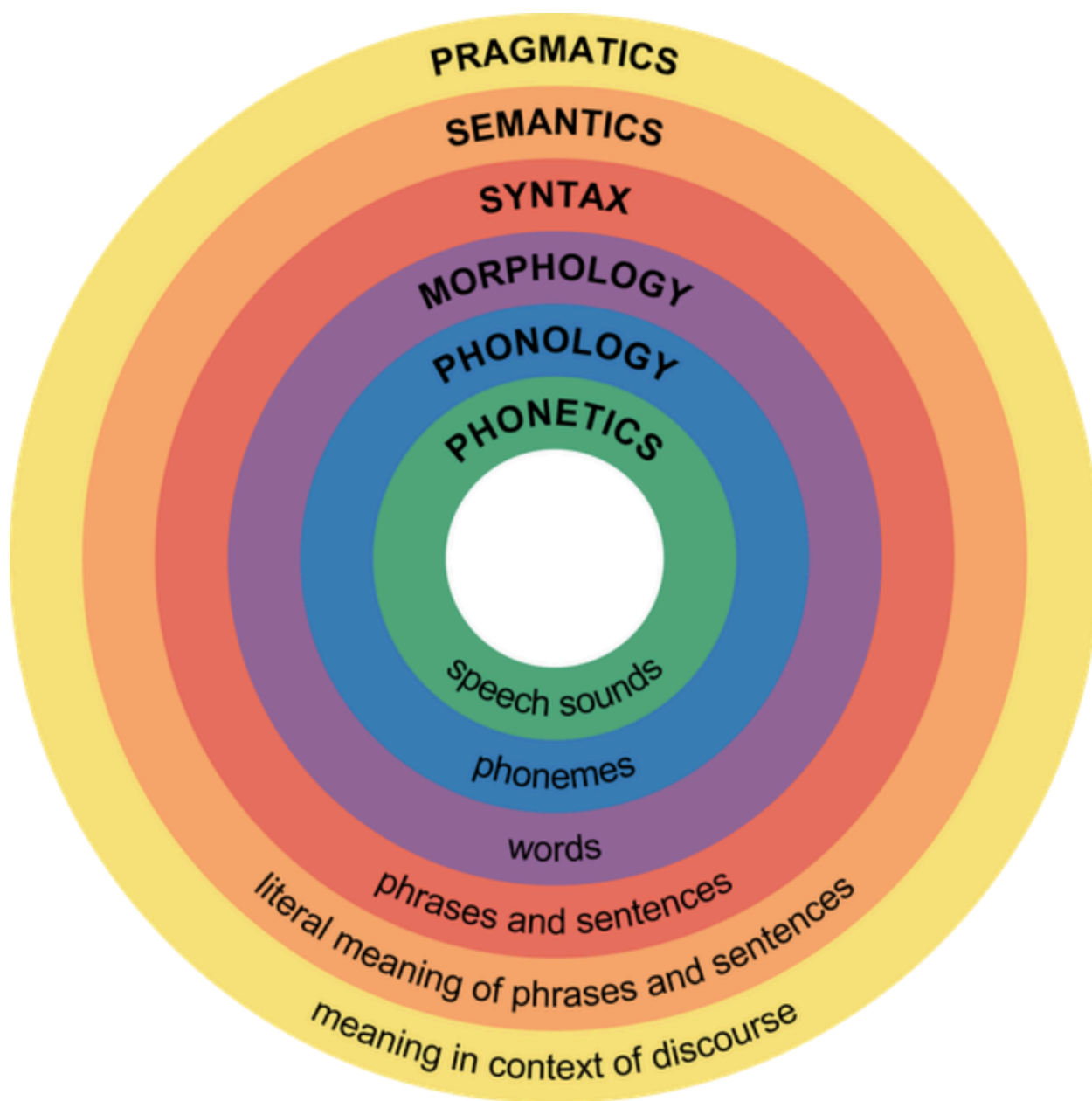
Language Acquisition: Linguistics studies how children and adults learn languages. It explores the processes involved in acquiring both native and second languages.

Cognitive Processing: Linguistics examines how language is processed in the human mind. It investigates how we understand and produce language.

Connection to the Social Sciences: Linguistics is closely connected to fields like anthropology, sociology, and psychology. It explores how language is linked to race, gender, and social identity.

Interdisciplinary Nature: Linguistics complements various disciplines, including philosophy, biology, computer science, and literature. It intersects with different areas of study to deepen our understanding of language.

Applied Linguistics: Applied Linguistics focuses on practical applications of linguistic theories. It helps improve communication skills in native or second languages, especially in educational settings.



What are phonemes?

A **phoneme** is a speech sound. It's the smallest unit of sound (which doesn't have any inherent meaning by itself) that distinguishes one word from another. Since sounds cannot be written, we use letters to represent or stand for the sounds.

Changing one phoneme in a word can produce another word. Example: in the word 'cat', changing the first phoneme can produce a word with a very different meaning, such as 'rat'.

Phonemes are written between slashes by convention. Example: /b/ & /p/

What is phonetics?

Phonetics is a branch of linguistics in which we study the sounds of a language produced by humans. It is the study of how sounds are produced, transmitted, and received. It is also the study of various organs of speech. In it, we study:

- Origin of sounds
- Sound transmission (how sound travels)
- Receiving of sound

Phonetics is important as it tells about the exact pronunciation of words & how difference in pronunciation might alter the meaning of the word.

International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA):

Phonetics describes these sounds using the symbols of the **International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA)**. IPA was developed to accurately represent the pronunciation of languages. The aim of IPA is to develop or provide a unique symbol for distinctive sounds in a language. **The International Phonetic Alphabet**, also called **IPA**, was developed by some linguistics to accurately represent languages' pronunciations. Its main purpose is to provide a unique symbol for each distinct sound in a language. While

the IPA contains **107** different vowels and consonants, no language uses all of them. In some languages such as **English around 44** of these sounds are used while in a language such as Spanish only 24 sounds are used.

IPA Functions:

There are so many uses of IPA that you may have encountered before. Here are the most important uses of IPA:

- The IPA is used in dictionaries (mostly the English ones) to indicate how words should be pronounced.
- Languages with no written script have often been written using the IPA.
- In some foreign language textbooks, the IPA is used to transcribe the sounds of languages not written in Latin. In order to learn English, non-native speakers also use it.

What is R. P. (Received Pronunciation) in English?

“RP is a way of pronouncing British English that is often considered to be the standard accent. Pronunciations in this dictionary are given in RP. RP is an abbreviation for 'Received Pronunciation'. (Collin Dictionary). English is spoken with different pronunciations in world. But English spoken in Britain is regarded as authentic English or Standard English. IPA, International Phonetic Alphabets has created Received Pronunciation R.P or B.E.

British phonetician Daniel Jones, in his English Pronunciation Dictionary (1917), used the term ‘public school pronunciation’ and subsequently used the term Received Pronunciation in second edition of the dictionary in 1926. There is considerable debate over the suitability of R.P. for all

the learners. Some scholars even used BBC English in place of R.P.. R.P. can be understood as an accepted or approved pronunciation.

What is GIE (General Indian English) or Indian English?

English is the official recognized language in India. In his book *The English Language* (1990), David Crystal observed, "British English is now, numerically speaking, a minority dialect, compared with American, or even Indian, English." (Wikipedia)

English is learned as a secondary language in India. Before learning English, we learn our mother tongue and form strong linguistic habits related to our mother tongue. The phonological system of their mother tongue will have an influence on the phonology of their English. India is a multilingual country with a variety of languages spoken across the region. These varieties of languages have an influence on English.

Importance of studying phonetics:

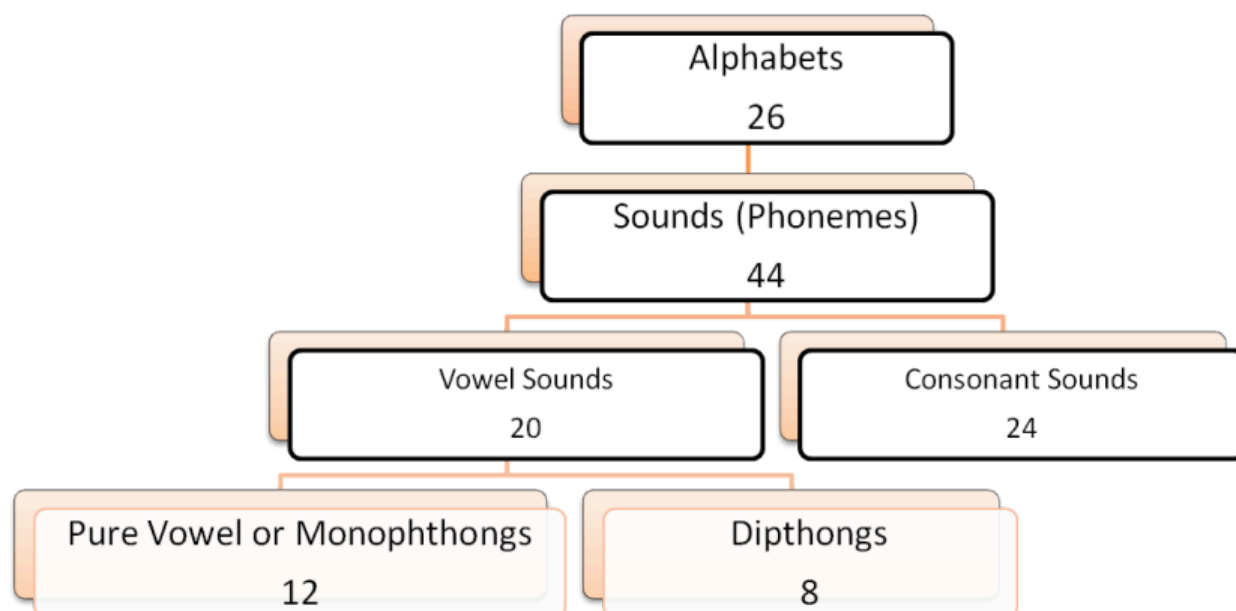
1. Phonetics helps us understand how sounds are produced in speech.
2. It enables accurate pronunciation.
3. It helps with clearer communication.
4. Studying phonetics aids in learning foreign languages more effectively.
5. It is essential for diagnosing and treating speech disorders.
6. Phonetics helps in developing better listening skills.
7. It provides insights into regional accents and dialects.
8. Understanding phonetics can improve singing and musical abilities.
9. It is crucial for developing speech recognition technology.

10. Phonetics assists in teaching reading and writing skills, especially for children.
11. It enhances overall communication competence in various contexts.
12. It builds confidence when learners understand how sounds correspond to letters and words; communication feels easy; and they can connect unfamiliar words with clear meanings without feeling anxious.
13. Learning phonetics helps people of all ages recognize and understand sounds, whether they're familiar or unfamiliar, enabling them to interpret words accurately, especially when spoken with different accents.
14. Learning phonetics helps people spell words correctly by understanding the relationship between sounds and letters, ensuring effective communication in both reading and writing.
15. Studying phonetics helps speakers become more fluent by improving their ability to recognize words quickly and pronounce them accurately.

Phonetics in detail:

In order to study the origin of sounds, we have to understand:

26 Alphabets = 5 vowels + 21 Consonants



Monophthongs: The word monophthong comes from the Greek “*mono*”, which means “one”, and “*-phthong*”, which means “tone” or “sound”. So monophthong means “one sound” or “single sound”. Monophthongs are called pure vowels. It is a vowel sound in which the tongue stays in one position. It is a pure vowel sound one whose articulation at both the beginning and end is relatively fixed, and which does not glide up or down towards a new position of articulation.

The monophthongs are as follows:

1. /i/ इ ex: ship, lip, dip, sin, sit, pill, kill, slip

2. /i:/ ई ex: sheep, beach, deep, easy, seat, field, reach

3. /ʊ/ उ ex: pull, foot, good, full, put

4. /u:/ ऊ ex: food, ooze, fool, shoot, school

5. /e/ ए ex: head, pet, set, end, bed

6. /ə/ अ ex: teacher, the, about middle

7. /ɜ:/ अर् ex: girl, earth, bird, stir

8. /ɔ:/ ओ ex: caught, saw, war, warm, door, floor

9. /æ/ ऐ ex: apple, hat, man, cat

10. /ʌ/ अ ex: love, sun, under up

11. /ɑ:/ आ ex: start, dark, father,

12. /ɒ/ ओ ex: from, not, on, of, hot, pot

Diphthongs: A diphthong is a vowel that contains two different vowel sounds in one syllable. The word diphthong comprises *di*, which means ‘two’ in Greek, and *phthong*, which means ‘sound’. Therefore, diphthong means two sounds.

Diphthongs are gliding vowels, created when a speaker glides from one vowel sound glides into another. The first vowel is usually longer and stronger than the second one in the English language. For example:

In the English word 'house', the vowel sound in the first syllable, /aʊ/ is a diphthong. It starts with the sound of the vowel /a/ and glides to the sound of the vowel /ʊ/. A diphthong is a single vowel sound formed by transitioning between two vowel sounds.

Here is another diphthong example: /ɔɪ/ is a diphthong. It is the 'oi' sound in words such as *boy* /bɔɪ/, *toy* /tɔɪ/, or *coin* /kɔɪn/.

The diphthongs are as follows:

There are eight different diphthongs in the English language. They are:

1. /eɪ/ एइ as in *late* (/leɪt/) or *gate* (/geɪt/)
2. /ɪə/ इअ as in *dear* (/diə/) or *fear* (/fiə/)
3. /eə/ एअ as in *fair* (/feə/) or *care* (/keə/)
4. /ʊə/ ओअ as in *sure* (/ʃʊə/) or *cure* (/kjʊə/)
5. /əʊ/ अओ as in *globe* (/ˈgləʊb/) or *show* (/ʃəʊ/)
6. /ɔɪ/ ओइ as in *join* (/dʒɔɪn/) or *coin* (/kɔɪn/)
7. /aɪ/ अइ as in *time* (/taɪm/) or *rhyme* (/raɪm/)
8. /aʊ/ अउ as in *cow* (/kaʊ/) or *how* (/haʊ/)

Consonant Sounds: A consonant sound is a speech sound that is produced by the partial or complete obstruction of air by the lips, teeth, tongue or throat. The Collins Dictionary defines a consonant sound as “a sound such as ‘p’, ‘f’, ‘n’, or ‘t’ which you pronounce by stopping the air flowing freely through your mouth”. There are 44 speech sounds in total in the English language. Among them, 24 are consonant sounds. Let us look at what they are and how they are classified.

The 24 Consonant Sounds in English:

S No.	Consonant Sounds	Examples
1.	/p/	pet, top
2.	/b/	bat, tub
3.	/m/	mat, palm
4.	/w/	wind, always
5.	/f/	front, leaf
6.	/v/	vase, advise
7.	/θ/	think, teeth
8.	/ð/	this, with
9.	/t/	trunk, what
10.	/d/	dose, ward
11.	/s/	save, case
12.	/z/	zest, doze
13.	/n/	neat, win
14.	/l/	like, will
15.	/r/	rest, torch
16.	/ʃ/	shoes, cushion
17.	/ʒ/	beige, measure
18.	/tʃ/	catch, patch
19.	/dʒ/	badge, judge
20.	/j/	yoke, yonder

21.	/k/	keep, poke
22.	/g/	game, bag
23.	/ŋ/	sing, wing
24.	/h/	heap, cohort

